

for distance, speed, and altitude. The distance contest, for the Grand Prix de la Champagne, was easily won by Henri Farman, who flew a record 112 miles (180km) before running out of fuel. The sight of his aircraft trundling around and around the circuit at low altitude for over three hours might not sound very exciting, but the response of the patriotic French crowd was delirious, to the point of threatening public order.

The prize for the highest speed over a distance of 19 miles (30km) was put up by the owner of the *Paris Herald* newspaper, Gordon Bennett. After other contestants fell out – the English pilot Cockburn ran into a haystack – the speed contest turned into a head-to-head between Blériot and Curtiss in his Reims Racer. Curtiss went first and later described his somewhat rough ride: “The sun was hot and the air rough, but I had resolved to keep the throttle wide open. I cut the corner as close as I dared and banked the machine high on the turns... In front of the tribunes the machine flew steadily, but when I got around on the back stretch... I found remarkable air conditions. The machine pitched considerably, and when I passed

above the ‘graveyard,’ where so many machines had gone down and were smashed during the previous days, the air seemed literally to drop from under me.” He survived to complete the distance with an average speed of 47mph (75kph). To the great disappointment of the patriotic crowd, Blériot took six seconds longer and the Stars and Stripes was run up over the grandstand.

In the end, perhaps the spectacle that most struck onlookers was the altitude contest. It was won by Latham in his elegant Antoinette, which rose to the unprecedented height of 508ft (155m). Most pilots still flew close to the ground; seeing an airplane shrink to little more than a dot as it climbed into the blue must have created an awesome impression.

Commercialization

The Blériot cross-Channel flight and the Reims meeting set the agenda for the immediate future of

THE LONDON-TO-MANCHESTER AIR RACE

IN APRIL 1910, English pilot Claude Grahame-White and Frenchman Louis Paulhan, both flying Farman biplanes, competed for the £10,000 (\$48,500) prize put up by Lord Northcliffe for the first flight from London to Manchester – a trip of 185 miles (296km).

Spotting a break in the bad weather on the evening of April 27, Paulhan got away first with the Englishman in hot pursuit. The French pilot followed a specially hired train along the railtrack between the two cities; Grahame-White also followed the rail line, with his supporters keeping up in a fleet of automobiles. Popular excitement was intense, and crowds, eager for the latest news, gathered outside newspaper offices in London and Paris. A huge map was set up in the Place de l’Opéra in central Paris, with model aircraft showing the race’s progress. When night fell,



A COLORFUL FIGURE

Claude Grahame-White was one of the most colourful characters in the early history of aviation. Automobiles were his first love, but in 1909 he attended Reims as a spectator and immediately fell in love with flying. He asked Blériot to build him an airplane and taught himself to fly.

both pilots landed alongside the railroad – no one had ever flown cross-country in darkness. Seeing his only chance of overtaking the Frenchman, Grahame-White decided to take off again in the moonlight, using the automobile headlamps to light up the field. Even this bold move was not enough to bring victory. Up at the crack of dawn and braving gusting winds, Paulhan reached Manchester by 5:32 am, ahead of the Englishman, who had been forced to land his wind-battered Farman short of the goal. Paulhan had spent 4 hours 18 minutes in the air.

FLIGHT PATH

Louis Paulhan’s Farman biplane is shown flying over railroad tracks during the London–Manchester airplane race. Both he and Grahame-White kept their bearings by following the railroad line.



flight. While military interest remained tentative, there was little official financial support for aviation, but the lure of fame and fortune, in the form of large cash prizes and appearance money, stimulated the drive toward improved performance and fresh achievements. The money mostly came from newspaper magnates – whose papers were engaged in bitter circulation wars with rivals – putting up cash for individual feats or long-distance races, and from ticket sales for the air meetings that proliferated in the wake of the commercial success of the Reims event. Even while the Reims meeting was going on, entrepreneurs were thrusting forward to sign up the pilots to appear at other hastily arranged air tournaments across Europe. These events were to give hundreds of thousands of people their very first sight of airplanes in flight.

The first follow-up meet, at Brescia in northern Italy, was held in September 1909. Curtiss, well on his way to becoming a wealthy man, again won the speed prize. In 1910, aviation meetings proliferated throughout Europe, with some 30 tournaments taking place in cities as diverse and widely scattered as St. Petersburg, Barcelona, Florence, Nice, Munich, Bournemouth,

